

Nocturia means waking from sleep to urinate. Getting up once a night is common, especially as we age. Waking **two or more times** often disturbs sleep, causes tiredness during the day and raises the risk of falls at night. You do not have to simply accept it. Most causes can be treated once the reason is found.

About This Condition

There are a few main reasons people wake to urinate. Many people have a **mix**:

- **Making too much urine at night** (nocturnal polyuria). Causes include drinks in the evening, caffeine, alcohol, salty evening meals, leg swelling, heart or kidney problems, sleep apnea, and water pills.
- **Making too much urine all day**, for example from high blood sugar.
- **A bladder that holds less**, from an overactive bladder, an enlarged prostate, or a bladder that does not empty well.
- **Poor sleep**. You wake for another reason, then get up to urinate.

Why It Matters

Getting up at night is linked to **falls and broken bones** in older adults. Nocturia can also be a sign of a health problem, such as sleep apnea, diabetes, or a heart or kidney problem. That is why it is worth checking.

Learn the Terms

Nocturia

Waking from sleep to urinate.

Nocturnal polyuria

Making too large a share of your daily urine at night.

Bladder diary

A record of when and how much you drink and urinate, day and night. Also called a frequency-volume chart.

Overactive bladder

A bladder that gives sudden, strong urges and holds less.

Sleep apnea

Breathing that stops and starts during sleep. It can make you produce more urine at night.

Desmopressin

A medicine that lowers urine made at night, for some patients.

The first step: a bladder diary. For at least 3 days, write down when and how much you drink and urinate, day and night, and when you go to sleep and wake up. This is the most useful test. It shows your team **which** cause is behind your nocturia, and that decides the treatment.

How It Is Checked

- A **bladder diary**, and a review of your drinks, medicines and sleep
- A **urine test**, and often blood tests for kidney function, sugar and salt levels
- A check for leg swelling, sleep apnea, and bladder or prostate problems

How It Is Treated

- 1 **Evening habits:** drink less in the 2–4 hours before bed, and limit evening caffeine, alcohol and salt.
- 2 **Leg swelling:** fluid that pools in the legs during the day returns to the blood when you lie down, and the kidneys turn it into urine at night. Raise your legs in the afternoon and wear compression stockings during the day. Ask whether any water pill can be taken earlier in the day.
- 3 **Treat the cause:** overactive bladder, an enlarged prostate, sleep apnea, diabetes, or heart or kidney problems.
- 4 **Desmopressin**, for some people who make too much urine at night. It needs blood tests for sodium (salt) before you start, within a week, and at one month. It is usually avoided in older adults because low sodium can be dangerous.

Staying Safe at Night

- Use a **night light** and keep a clear path to the bathroom. A bedside commode can help.
- Stand up slowly, especially if you take blood pressure medicines.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Blood in the urine, burning, or a temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher
- On desmopressin: headache, nausea, vomiting, muscle cramps or unusual tiredness. Stop the medicine and call.

Go to an emergency department if:

- On desmopressin: confusion, a seizure, or you are very hard to wake
- You have trouble breathing
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Nocturia is common, but it often has a cause that can be treated.
2. A bladder diary kept for at least 3 days is the key first step.
3. Prevent falls at night with a light and a clear path.